

The Estimate Bottleneck

One approver on every sale is capping throughput and burning out our most experienced man. Here's the fix that protects him.

Our shop's total output is limited not by how many techs we have, but by how fast one person can personally inspect and price every car. That's a structural ceiling — and it's wearing down the person we can least afford to lose.

WHAT IT'S COSTING — THREE WAYS

THROUGHPUT

Idle bays

Techs finish, then wait for approval. Clocked but not billing — the exact billed-vs-clocked leak.

MARGIN VARIANCE

Under + over

No standard estimate = inconsistent pricing. Underselling bleeds ARO; overselling risks trust + PA liability.

KEY-PERSON RISK

One skull

The whole sales process lives in one person. Sick day, vacation, or retirement = revenue stops. Nothing to hand off.

THE REFRAME — PROTECT THE ASSET, DON'T REMOVE IT

Our manager insisting on eyes for every car isn't the problem — it's a sign of how much he cares. But a man with 35 years of diagnostic instinct personally pricing every oil change is our best asset spent on our cheapest work. **The goal isn't to take authority away from him. It's to stop wasting his time and his knees on the calls that never needed him.**

THE FIX — PHASED, LOW-RISK

1. Video DVI (start here)

Techs shoot a 15-second clip of the actual failure and push it to his tablet. For clear-cut work he prices it from his desk — no walk to the bay. For real judgment calls he still goes out. The same video goes to the customer's phone, so they see exactly what we see: fewer disputes, more approvals.

2. Approval thresholds (later, once #1 sticks)

He keeps full authority on big-ticket, safety, and judgment work — where 35 years earns its keep. Routine maintenance under a set dollar line flows from the tech's video straight to the writer. Unclogs the gate for the ~70% of work that never needed him.

HOW TO INTRODUCE IT

Frame it as protecting his time, not removing his authority — he still makes every call; the video just saves the trips to the bay that never needed him. Lead with curiosity, not a verdict: worth understanding what made him start checking every car himself before changing anything. The system, not any one person, becomes the reason the workflow improves.

OWNER ANGLE — THIS IS LIABILITY PROTECTION, NOT JUST SALES

The customer-approved video is documented, timestamped authorization. Under Pennsylvania's strengthened 2024 Automotive Industry Trade Practices regulation, that's the proof that covers the shop in a dispute. Video DVI doesn't just lift approvals — it converts our biggest compliance exposure into a defensible record.

Recommended next step: 30-day measurement — track estimate turnaround time, idle tech hours, ARO, and comeback rate, so the decision rests on data, not opinion. Prepared by CFO Agent · Heilman Auto Group.